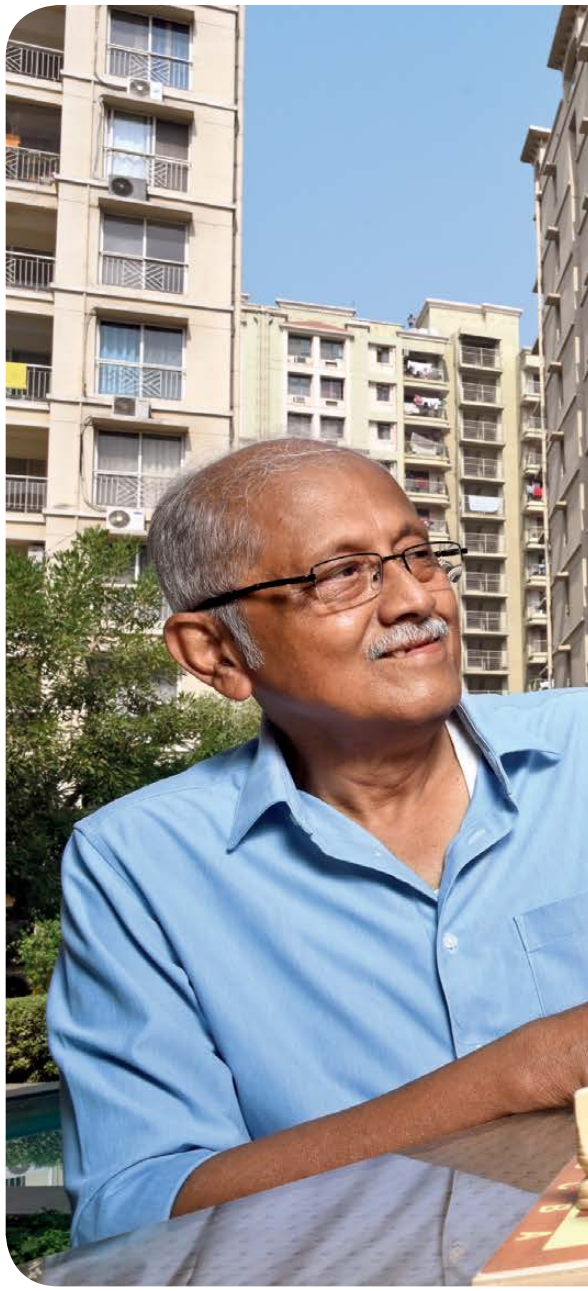
The Suds left their spacious five-room house in Gurugram and relocated to Antara about two years ago. Anil had contracted herpes, and it had become extremely difficult for the octogenarian couple to manage both health and household. "Antara is not heaven, it is heavenly," says Anil. "It is four-button living here; you press the keys, and work gets done."

They are the golden oldies, or The Goldies, if you will. They are driven by the desire to live independently, be with like-minded people, remain physically and cognitively engaged, battle loneliness, not worry about daily chores and be close to healthcare services. The fact that they also have the financial wherewithal to make the choice helps. The Covid-19 pandemic made them realise that life is short and unpredictable and to make the most of one's remaining years. Community living in plush environs, therefore, has become a lifestyle choice for many older Indians like the Suds.

According to the United Nations Population Fund's India Ageing Report, 2023, India currently has 149 million people—nearly 10 per cent of its total population—above the age of 60. This is expected to rise to 347 million people, or 20 per cent of India's population by 2050. In fact, the elderly will overtake the number of children between zero and 14 years of age by the end of this century. So, despite India's much-touted 'demographic dividend' of young people, the longer-term trend is towards an 'ageing India'. There is also a growing trend of seniors living alone or with their spouse. According to the Union ministry of health and family welfare's Longitudinal Ageing Study, 2021, out of the 72,250 individuals above the age of 45 years surveyed, 5.7 per cent above the age of 60 were living alone and 20.3 per cent with their spouse (see *How the Elderly Live*).

With a demographic like this, can business opportunity be far behind? Taking note of this emerging customer base, entrepreneurs are developing offerings that cater to the lifestyle aspirations as well as the well-being of the elderly. So whether it's housing, healthcare or convenience services, wearable tech, lifestyle products, travel, entertainment or financial products, every offering has a silvern edge.

Consulting firm PwC estimates that the elder economy is already a $10-15 billion (Rs 83,300-Rs 1.25 lakh crore) market in India, slated to grow at 13-15 per cent year on year across its various segments. These include home healthcare services, senior living, lifestyle products and non-health services related to travel, finance and convenience. "The elder market in India is relatively new," says Dr Rana Mehta, partner and healthcare leader at PwC India, "as the first generation of seniors who accumulated wealth during the post-liberalisation period of the '90s have entered this demographic. Over the past 5-10 years, services catering to this customer base have demonstrated both cultural acceptance and financial viability, which will accelerate investments in the sector in the coming years."



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

$10-15 BILLION
ELDERCARE MARKET* IN INDIA

13-15 PER CENT
YOY GROWTH RATE

149 MILLION
PEOPLE ABOVE THE AGE OF 60 IN 2022, OR 10.5% OF INDIA'S POPULATION

347 MILLION
PROJECTED NUMBERS OF SENIORS BY 2050, OR 21% OF TOTAL POPULATION

**Includes home healthcare services, senior living, lifestyle products, travel, financial and convenience services*

Source: PwC India; UNFPA India Ageing Report 2023